

Advertisement

SOCIAL



Substack rival Ghost connects to the open social web with its latest public release

After [months of beta testing](#), newsletter platform [Ghost](#) has [shipped](#) a new version of its software, Ghost 6, that allows its publishers to share their long-form content natively with the broader open social web. That means in addition to publishing their newsletters to the web, RSS, and sending them out via email, Ghost's users can also natively connect with services like the decentralized X rival Mastodon; Meta's Threads; Flipboard; WordPress sites that have integrated with ActivityPub, Surf, and WriteFreely; and others.

While Ghost also mentions the ability to publish to Bluesky as a part of this release, that's [made possible](#) through an integration with [Bridgy Fed](#), a service that connects the [open social web known as fediverse](#) to the one called the [ATmosphere](#). The former is powered by an open standard for decentralized social networking called [ActivityPub](#), whereas the latter works with the newer [AT Protocol](#) used by Bluesky and other apps.

[Manton Reece](#), the founder of the publishing platform [Micro.blog](#), pointed out the difference between [his service and Ghost's](#), noting that Micro.blog has been working on direct AT Protocol integration while Ghost is using bridging.

TEC DISRUPT

October 27-29, 2025 | San Francisco

Put your brand in front of 10,000+ tech and VC leaders across all three days of Disrupt 2025. Amplify your reach, spark real connections, and lead the innovation charge. Secure your exhibit space before your competitor does.

[Book Your Table >](#)

Most Popular



- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a \$2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion



Manton Reece
@manton.org



Ghost 6.0 has been released, adding ActivityPub. Big update. It's interesting how Ghost now talks about Bluesky compatibility, which works via Bridgy Fed, but they don't mention Bridgy Fed. This feels slightly wrong to me since I've spent so much time working on AT Protocol.

Aug 4, 2025 at 3:21 PM

5 4 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32 33 34 35 36 37 38 39 40 41 42 43 44 45 46 47 48 49 50 51 52 53 54 55 56 57 58 59 60 61 62 63 64 65 66 67 68 69 70 71 72 73 74 75 76 77 78 79 80 81 82 83 84 85 86 87 88 89 90 91 92 93 94 95 96 97 98 99 100 101 102 103 104 105 106 107 108 109 110 111 112 113 114 115 116 117 118 119 120 121 122 123 124 125 126 127 128 129 130 131 132 133 134 135 136 137 138 139 140 141 142 143 144 145 146 147 148 149 150 151 152 153 154 155 156 157 158 159 160 161 162 163 164 165 166 167 168 169 170 171 172 173 174 175 176 177 178 179 180 181 182 183 184 185 186 187 188 189 190 191 192 193 194 195 196 197 198 199 200 201 202 203 204 205 206 207 208 209 210 211 212 213 214 215 216 217 218 219 220 221 222 223 224 225 226 227 228 229 230 231 232 233 234 235 236 237 238 239 240 241 242 243 244 245 246 247 248 249 250 251 252 253 254 255 256 257 258 259 260 261 262 263 264 265 266 267 268 269 270 271 272 273 274 275 276 277 278 279 280 281 282 283 284 285 286 287 288 289 290 291 292 293 294 295 296 297 298 299 300 301 302 303 304 305 306 307 308 309 310 311 312 313 314 315 316 317 318 319 320 321 322 323 324 325 326 327 328 329 330 331 332 333 334 335 336 337 338 339 340 341 342 343 344 345 346 347 348 349 350 351 352 353 354 355 356 357 358 359 360 361 362 363 364 365 366 367 368 369 370 371 372 373 374 375 376 377 378 379 380 381 382 383 384 385 386 387 388 389 390 391 392 393 394 395 396 397 398 399 400 401 402 403 404 405 406 407 408 409 410 411 412 413 414 415 416 417 418 419 420 421 422 423 424 425 426 427 428 429 430 431 432 433 434 435 436 437 438 439 440 441 442 443 444 445 446 447 448 449 450 451 452 453 454 455 456 457 458 459 460 461 462 463 464 465 466 467 468 469 470 471 472 473 474 475 476 477 478 479 480 481 482 483 484 485 486 487 488 489 490 491 492 493 494 495 496 497 498 499 500 501 502 503 504 505 506 507 508 509 510 511 512 513 514 515 516 517 518 519 520 521 522 523 524 525 526 527 528 529 530 531 532 533 534 535 536 537 538 539 540 541 542 543 544 545 546 547 548 549 550 551 552 553 554 555 556 557 558 559 560 561 562 563 564 565 566 567 568 569 570 571 572 573 574 575 576 577 578 579 580 581 582 583 584 585 586 587 588 589 590 591 592 593 594 595 596 597 598 599 600 601 602 603 604 605 606 607 608 609 610 611 612 613 614 615 616 617 618 619 620 621 622 623 624 625 626 627 628 629 630 631 632 633 634 635 636 637 638 639 640 641 642 643 644 645 646 647 648 649 650 651 652 653 654 655 656 657 658 659 660 661 662 663 664 665 666 667 668 669 670 671 672 673 674 675 676 677 678 679 680 681 682 683 684 685 686 687 688 689 690 691 692 693 694 695 696 697 698 699 700 701 702 703 704 705 706 707 708 709 710 711 712 713 714 715 716 717 718 719 720 721 722 723 724 725 726 727 728 729 730 731 732 733 734 735 736 737 738 739 740 741 742 743 744 745 746 747 748 749 750 751 752 753 754 755 756 757 758 759 760 761 762 763 764 765 766 767 768 769 770 771 772 773 774 775 776 777 778 779 780 781 782 783 784 785 786 787 788 789 790 791 792 793 794 795 796 797 798 799 800 801 802 803 804 805 806 807 808 809 810 811 812 813 814 815 816 817 818 819 820 821 822 823 824 825 826 827 828 829 830 831 832 833 834 835 836 837 838 839 840 841 842 843 844 845 846 847 848 849 850 851 852 853 854 855 856 857 858 859 860 861 862 863 864 865 866 867 868 869 870 871 872 873 874 875 876 877 878 879 880 881 882 883 884 885 886 887 888 889 890 891 892 893 894 895 896 897 898 899 900 901 902 903 904 905 906 907 908 909 910 911 912 913 914 915 916 917 918 919 920 921 922 923 924 925 926 927 928 929 930 931 932 933 934 935 936 937 938 939 940 941 942 943 944 945 946 947 948 949 950 951 952 953 954 955 956 957 958 959 960 961 962 963 964 965 966 967 968 969 970 971 972 973 974 975 976 977 978 979 980 981 982 983 984 985 986 987 988 989 990 991 992 993 994 995 996 997 998 999 1000

- Lina Khan points to Figma IPO as vindication of M&A scrutiny
- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines

ActivityPub has long been used to power open, decentralized social media applications. But in the years after Twitter's acquisition by Elon Musk, there has been an increased interest in building with this protocol as competitors to Twitter (now called X) emerged.

Meta launched its alternative to X in [2023 with Instagram Threads](#), which has been [catching up to](#) X on mobile devices. Meanwhile, blogging platform [WordPress](#), including the hosted version WordPress.com, now offers the ability to integrate with ActivityPub, allowing users to follow WordPress blogs on services like Mastodon. Other apps have integrated with the open social web as well, such as [Flipboard's](#) flagship app and newer app [Surf](#), and [publishing platform Medium](#).

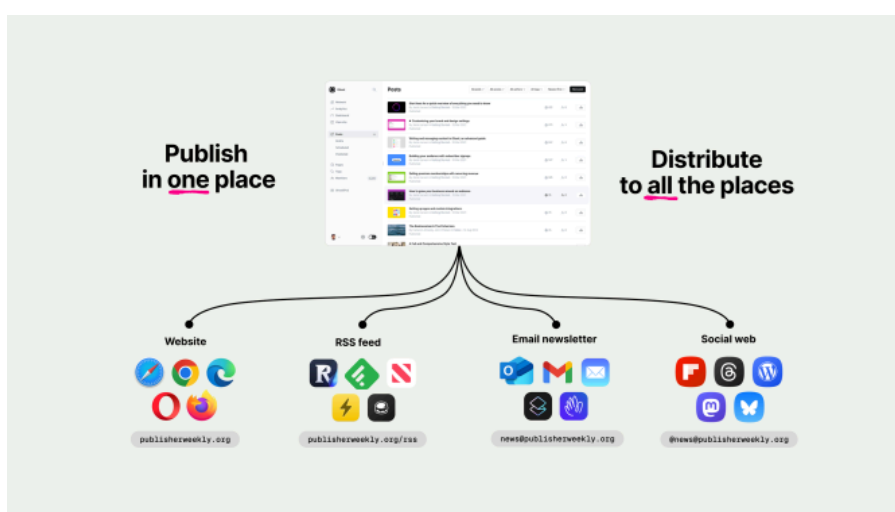


IMAGE CREDITS:GHOST

Ghost also touted the potential network effects of connecting with ActivityPub, because it allows

people on federated apps to then follow a Ghost publisher's posts, as well as interact with them by liking, replying, or reposting. This potentially broadens the publishers' reach and expands their readership.

In addition, Ghost's users can keep up with other long-form content in an "Inbox" section of its software, where they can follow other articles published on Ghost or WordPress. Plus, from Ghost's admin screen, publishers will have the ability to post short-form content to the fediverse, allowing them to grow their following and connect with readers.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

[REGISTER NOW](#)

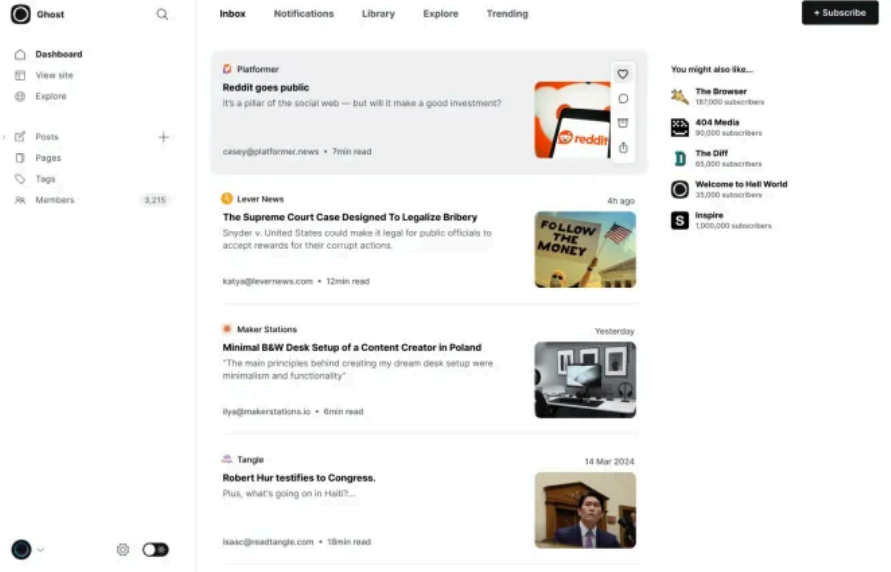


IMAGE CREDITS :GHOST

Ghost 6 arrives shortly after a shameful incident from its top competitor, the newsletter platform Substack, which [sent a push notification](#) to users encouraging them to subscribe to a Nazi newsletter. Several authors have already left Substack over its decision to host such content in the past, including Casey Newton of Platformer, a popular tech publication. Other notable Ghost [publications](#) include [404 Media](#), [Spyglass](#), David Sirota’s [The Lever](#), [Tangle](#), Jason Calacanis’s Inside, SFist, and others.

The company shared that its publishers have generated over \$100 million, leaving Ghost with annual revenue of \$8.5 million.

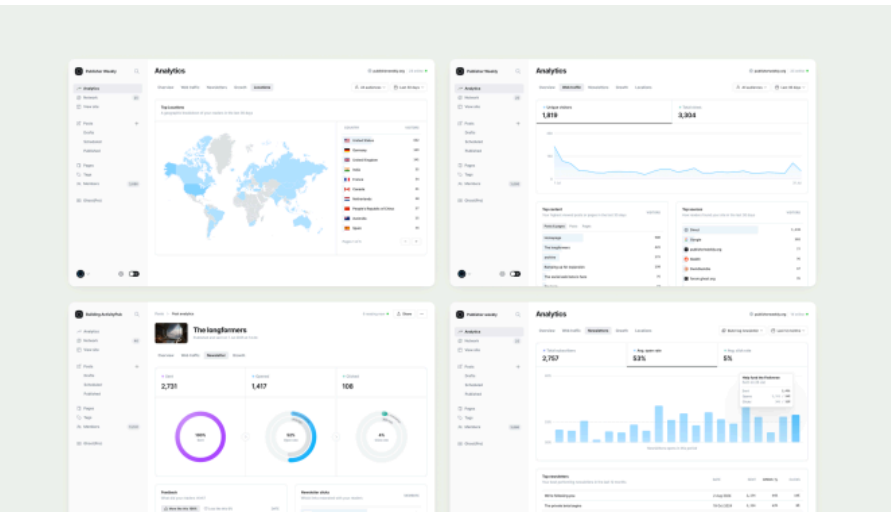


IMAGE CREDITS :GHOST

While the ActivityPub integration is a main selling point for Ghost 6, this major release includes a number of other changes and new additions. Notably, [Ghost now ships with](#) a native analytics suite that tracks performance, engagement, and conversions across the web, newsletters, and subscriptions in real time.

The software also supports a variety of payment methods, tips and donations, branded newsletters, content that can be personalized to individual readers, and more.

With the release, Ghost [adjusted](#) its pricing for its Pro (hosted) plans; its cheapest plans now start at \$15 and \$29 per month, up from \$9 and \$25 per month, respectively. Ghost publishers with a large number of subscribers, however, will now see reduced pricing.

Topics: [activitypub](#) [fediverse](#) [ghost](#)

[Media & Entertainment](#) [newsletters](#) [publishers](#)

[Social](#) [social](#)

[f](#) [X](#) [in](#) [👤](#) [✉](#) [🔗](#)



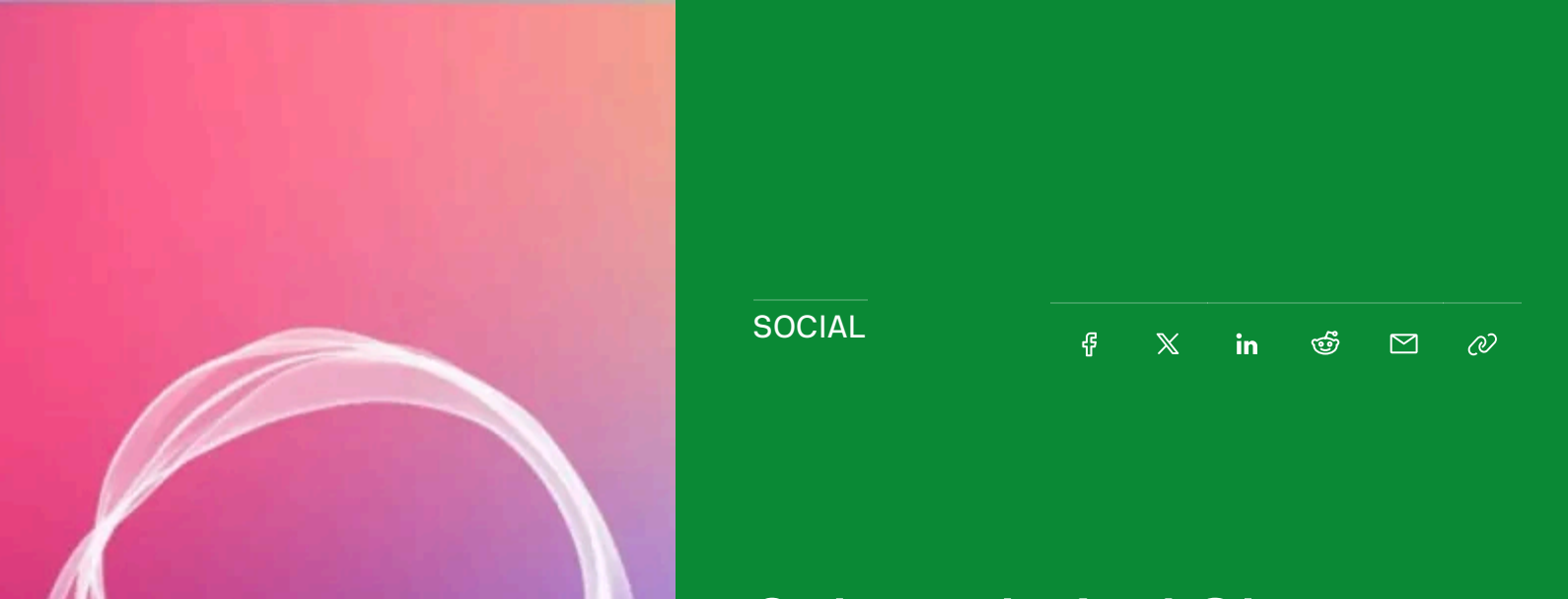
Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [m](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

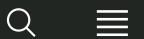
KEEP READING



SOCIAL



- Latest
- Startups
- Venture
- Apple
- Security
- AI
- Apps



- Events
- Podcasts
- Newsletters

Newsletter platform and Substack rival [Ghost announced earlier this year](#) that it would join the fediverse, [the open social network](#) of interconnected servers that includes apps like Mastodon, Pixelfed, PeerTube, Flipboard and, more recently, [Instagram Threads](#), among others. Now, it has made good on that promise — with its own newsletter as a start.

Over the past few days, Ghost says it has achieved two major milestones in its move to become a federated service. Of note, it has federated its own newsletter, making it the first federated Ghost instance on the internet.

Newsletters

See More ↗

Subscribe for the industry's biggest tech news

TechCrunch Daily News



Every weekday and Sunday, you can get the best of TechCrunch's coverage.

Users can follow the newsletter through their preferred federated app at @index@activitypub.ghost.org, though the company warns there will be bugs and issues as it continues to work on the platform's integration with [ActivityPub](#), the protocol that powers Mastodon and other federated apps.

“Having multiple Ghost instances in production successfully running ActivityPub is a huge milestone for us because it means that for the first time, we’re interacting with the wider fediverse. Not just theoretical local implementations and tests, but the real world wide social web,” the company shared in its announcement of the news.

In addition, Ghost's ActivityPub GitHub repository is now fully open source. That means those interested in tracking Ghost's progress toward federation can follow its code changes in real time, and anyone else can learn from, modify, distribute or contribute to its work. Developers who want to collaborate with Ghost are also being invited to get involved following this move.

The company had earlier detailed the benefits of an ActivityPub integration as an alternative to closed platforms, like Substack and others.

By offering a federated version of the newsletter, readers will have more choices on how they want to subscribe. That is, instead of only being able to follow the newsletter via email or the web, they also can track it using RSS or ActivityPub-powered apps, like Mastodon and others. Ghost said it will also develop a way for sites with paid subscribers to manage access via ActivityPub, but that functionality hasn't yet rolled out with this initial test.

Startups Weekly



Startups are the core of TechCrunch, so get our best coverage delivered weekly.

TechCrunch Week in Review



Get the best of our coverage, delivered to your inbox every Saturday.

TechCrunch Mobility



TechCrunch Mobility is your destination for transportation news and insight.

No newsletters selected.

Email address

Subscribe

By submitting your email, you agree to our [Terms](#) and [Privacy Notice](#).



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They're here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don't miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

San Francisco | October 27-29, 2025

REGISTER NOW

ActivityPub integration is becoming more common in the media business, as writers and publishers grapple with reduced traffic from sources like Google and Facebook while AI technology summarizes their work, either through paid [content deals](#) or [plagiarism](#). Several sites, including The Verge, MacRumors and MacStories (and soon TechCrunch) recently adopted a [new feature that will add their reporters' bylines to news articles](#) when they appeared in the fediverse, for instance.

Ghost itself has also [attracted](#) several high-profile users to its platform, often because Substack's lax moderation policies meant it was [increasingly becoming a home for hate speech](#). Casey Newton, formerly of The Verge, [left Substack](#) this year due to moderation concerns and [migrated](#) to Ghost instead. Another newsletter, [Garbage Day, also left](#) Substack. Other popular Ghost-powered publishers include 404 Media, Buffer, Kickstarter, David Sirota's The Lever and Tangle, to name a few.

Topics: [fediverse](#) [ghost](#) [Mastodon](#) [newsletter](#)

[Social](#) [Substack](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🐼](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

KEEP READING



APPS

Open source Substack rival Ghost may join the fediverse

Sarah Perez — 12:37 PM PDT · April 15, 2024

IMAGE CREDITS:

GHOST (EDITED BY BRYCE DURBIN/TECHCRUNCH)

Ghost, the open source [alternative](#) to Substack's newsletter platform, is considering joining the fediverse, the social network of interconnected servers that includes apps like [Mastodon](#), Pixelfed, PeerTube, [Flipboard](#) and, more recently, [Instagram Threads](#), among others. According to a [post](#) from Ghost founder John O'Nolan, the company — which is [structured as a nonprofit](#) — is considering federating Ghost over ActivityPub, the social networking protocol that powers the fediverse.

O'Nolan said that the most requested feature over the past few years has been to federate his software. "It seems like there are many potential ways to do it. Curious to hear how you would want it to work?" he asked in [a post on Threads](#), which was syndicated to Mastodon via Threads' own integration with ActivityPub.

The survey asks users if they use any ActivityPub platforms like Mastodon or Threads, and how they would expect ActivityPub functionality to work in Ghost, if it were to be added. It also asks how federation would personally benefit Ghost users. It invites survey respondents to optionally provide an email address if they want to be contacted for more input in the future, as well.

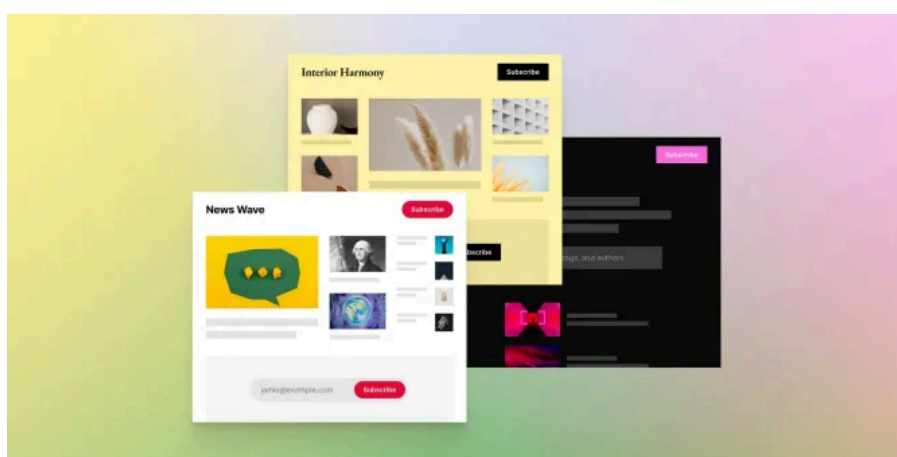


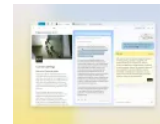
IMAGE CREDITS: GHOST

While the launch of a survey isn't necessarily a commitment to federating Ghost, it is another signal pointing to the [broader reshaping of the web that's now underway](#).

Latest in Apps

[See More](#)

APPS



The Browser Company launches a \$20 monthly subscription for its AI-powered browser

Ivan Mehta - 2 hours ago

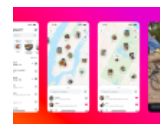
AI



Google takes on ChatGPT's Study Mode with new 'Guided Learning' tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

APPS



Instagram takes on Snapchat with new 'Instagram Map'

Aisha Malik - 18 hours ago

Following Twitter’s acquisition by billionaire Elon Musk, online users have experienced the downsides of putting their trust in centralized platforms: With a shift in ownership, Twitter was overhauled to be a different type of platform called X, with revised ethics and long-term ambitions. (Musk wants X to be an “everything” app for transactions, creator content, video, shopping and more and takes a more hands-off role in terms of content moderation.)

For those unhappy with Musk’s changes, having a portable social networking identity suddenly seemed like an idea that had more value. That is, if you don’t like the way your Mastodon server (or other federated service) is run, you can pick up your profile and move it elsewhere, [followers in tow](#).

With Ghost, however, the idea could be to federate the accounts of the writers who use Ghost to publish their content. Their posts, which would also be published on the web and to their newsletter subscribers, could also exist in the fediverse, where others could read, like and reply to the post from their preferred app. These replies could also potentially syndicate back to Ghost, where they could exist as comments.



Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

Netflix, ElevenLabs, Wayve, Sequoia Capital — just a few of the heavy hitters joining the Disrupt 2025 agenda. They’re here to deliver the insights that fuel startup growth and sharpen your edge. Don’t miss the 20th anniversary of TechCrunch Disrupt, and a chance to learn from the top voices in tech — grab your ticket now and save up to \$675 before prices rise on August 7.

REGISTER NOW

Assuming Ghost went this route, it would be similar to how [WordPress federated](#) with ActivityPub after the [acquisition of](#) an ActivityPub blog plug-in. When enabled, WordPress blogs can be followed by people on apps like Mastodon and others in the fediverse and then receive replies as comments on their own sites.

After seeing O’Nolan’s post, Mastodon CTO Renaud Chaput [reached out to help](#) with the ActivityPub integration, which O’Nolan accepted.

Ghost has gained attention as a Substack rival in recent months for the same reason that some have fled X: People disagree about how platforms should be moderated. Substack has taken to promoting free speech, as Musk does on X, but that’s also led to the platform [being used by pro-Nazi publications](#), as detailed by The Atlantic late last year.

As a result, one of Substack’s more high-profile writers, Casey Newton, formerly of The Verge, [left Substack](#) and [migrated](#) to Ghost instead.

“I’m not aware of any major U.S. consumer internet platform that does not explicitly ban praise for Nazi hate speech, much less one that welcomes them to set up shop and start selling subscriptions,” Newton wrote at the time.

In addition to Newton, [other notable Ghost users](#) include 404 Media, Buffer, Kickstarter, David Sirota’s The Lever and Tangle, to name a few.

Today, Ghost has been installed [over 3 million times](#), which would make for a healthy addition to the wider fediverse and its roughly [13+ million total users](#), around 1.5 million of which are active

monthly. (This figure doesn't include Threads' [130+ million monthly active users](#) as it's not fully integrated with [ActivityPub](#) as of yet.)

[How Twitter's descent into chaos is paving the way for a new web](#)

Topics: [Apps](#) [fediverse](#) [ghost](#) [Instagram Threads](#)

[Mastodon](#)



Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [M](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

[View Bio](#) >

Loading the next article



[TechCrunch Staff](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Advertise](#)

[Crunchboard Jobs](#)

[Site Map](#)

[Terms of Service](#)

[Privacy Policy](#)

[RSS Terms of Use](#)

[OpenAI](#)

[Perplexity](#)

[Cisco](#)

[DeepMind](#)

[Windsurf](#)

[Tech Layoffs](#)

[ChatGPT](#)